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RE Nomination of Yasmine Krings for Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants

January 31, 2026

To Whom It May Concern:

I write this cover letter as vice chair and chair of the teaching committee in the Department of Asian Languages and Cultures in full support of the nomination of Yasmine Krings for the 2026 Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants.

Yasmine is a ninth year Ph.D. student in ALC, working on a dissertation project entitled *Mixed Race at the End of Empire: Racial Melodrama, Impossibility, and National Belonging in Postwar Japan.* She entered the program in Fall of 2017 and has been serving as a teaching assistant in our department since her first teaching assignment in 2018.

Yasmine ranks among the very best of our teaching assistants. She is as an extremely capable teacher and discussion leader, and was so from her very first assignment in Fall 2018, her first experience as a TA. Her consistently outstanding course evaluation scores and expressions of appreciation from her students attest to that excellence.

What is remarkable is not only the superlative scores and comments from students (numerically, Yasmine's scores are regularly pegged close to the highest possible score) but how consistent those scores and comments are from 2018 to the present. As a beginning Ph.D. student, throughout the pandemic, and into the present, the student response to Yasmine's teaching across course topics and modalities has been astonishingly positive. Her ability to integrate her discussion sections with the course, and her conduct of class discussions, are uniformly described in superlative terms. To take only a few examples:

"Yasmine was an incredibly helpful, well-versed, and knowledgeable TA that made this class incredibly enjoyable. Rather than stressing about grades, Yasmine was able to have us focus on the course material in every discussion section in an interactive and collaborative manner. She always reiterated that she was there if anyone ever needed any help and gave detailed feedback on assignments. She facilitated great discussions around the class materials and was able to expand upon course topics in a relevant and engaging manner." (Japan 50, Fall 2020)

"Phenomenal TA. She led the section flawlessly and made it incredibly fun and entertaining while at the same time making it incredibly informative. I learned so much in the section. I really like how she structured the section as it enabled us to succeed in the class. She is incredibly accommodating and caring." (Japan 50, Fall 2020)

“Yasmine is one of the best TAs I’ve had. Very patient when students have not done the reading and when students don't feel like speaking up. She is very helpful with our midterms and finals and was very easy to talk about problems we might be having with the course. Her explanation of the required works, as well as the time periods, were detailed but easy to understand and she often sent out emails with details she covered as well as ones she might have missed. Absolutely nothing to complain about.” (Japan 70, Winter 2021)

“Yasmine is very approachable and highly communicative. She always provides detailed summaries of what happens during a discussion that week and is very organized in her emails about course logistics. During office hours, Yasmine was very helpful in clarifying what she was expecting and what the course was expecting regarding postings or the midterm and final papers. She seemed genuinely invested in her work as a TA because she provided many feedback pointers on the midterm paper, which I had not had from a TA before. During discussions, she always offered her analysis of the films or texts we were analyzing that week.” (Japan 70, Winter 2025)

Students regularly use superlatives – Yasmine is “amazing,” yet at the same time “real”; she is knowledgeable about the material, but centers her teaching on the needs of the students. She is always willing to help, is “considerate” and “caring,” and goes above and beyond to accommodate her students in discussion section and in office hours. It is clear that Yasmine takes a “leave no student behind approach,” working with individual students to meet their needs and to ensure their success in learning.

As the comments in her course evaluations attest, her teaching has had a deep effect on her students, across courses and from the beginning of her teaching career to the present. In her classes Yasmine has endeavored to create learning environments that are sensitive to students’ different circumstances and backgrounds. Yasmine’s work as a Teaching Assistant has been superlative—an evaluation supported by the numbers but also, importantly, by the students and instructors she has taught with. I recommend Yasmine to you with enthusiasm and no reservation whatsoever, and urge you to give our nomination your highest consideration.

Sincerely,



Chris Hanscom
Professor, Modern Korean Literature
Vice Chair and Chair of the Teaching Committee
Department of Asian Languages and Cultures, UCLA

Teaching Self-Statement

Since I began teaching in 2018, I have dedicated myself to improving my teaching and mentoring skills and to exploring how to transform general education and undergraduate courses in my department. Many general education courses are taught in a particular way because of legacy; they are structured the way they are because that was how it was taught to or handed down to the instructor. The courses in my department are structured the same as the general education courses I took as an undergraduate in 2010: short weekly responses, exams largely based on rote memorization, a major essay, learning objectives that are passive learning about history and culture, discussion sections that are Socratic. While I was familiar with the style, I did not become aware of issues until I began teaching myself. The courses assessed rote memorization (which students felt were "useless" or "irrelevant") or skills (writing, analysis) that were not taught and, with such large class sizes, it was impossible to ensure that every student was an active discussant or that they got the attention and help that they needed. This style is old-fashioned; it implicitly values education as fact-memorization and success as based on a student's ability to swim not sink when thrown into the "deep end."

Because my faculty have been open to constructive comments, it has been easier to advocate for my students and to strategize how we can better focus learning objectives, create scaffolding, and assess in ways that are fair and flexible for students. Through feedback and suggestions, some courses such as Japanese history have undergone significant restructuring, but other courses which are one-offs taught by different instructors are not able to benefit from previous feedback. Part of my pedagogical learning has been geared towards creating "patch fixes" that can be used to provide support to students when courses are already in progress and cannot be changed to provide more scaffolding. Thinking of how to teach and assess critical

thinking in history classes and of how to reinforce writing skills in media and culture classes have been my primary motivation in seeking additional pedagogical training outside of my department. I have taken workshops through TLC and at the end of this quarter, I will have completed the Writing Pedagogy Certificate (English Composition Track). The writing program, in particular, has helped me discuss and draft different teaching documents, exchange strategies for active learning and participation, create micro-teaching writing exercises that could be incorporated into content-heavy courses, among other things.

My department is aware of my passion for teaching because of my vocal advocacy for the need to create inclusive classrooms and to transform general education courses from a begrudging formality into coursework whose value is immediately apparent or, at the very least, understood by the time students leave. But my department's knowledge of my dedication is confined to this fact and to my teaching evaluations. My students, on the other hand, are most able to speak to my dedication because they are aware of the time and effort that I put into making class enjoyable, useful, and effective, of the importance I place in their direct feedback on my teaching "experiments," and of ensuring that they get the help they need, even if it goes beyond the standard expectations and duties of a TA. For my teaching artifacts, I have included a range of examples of how I have attempted to create inclusive classrooms, foster active learning, teach writing balanced with content, and provide effective feedback. Each artifact explains why it is a good example of my commitment to my students' learning with the final artifact serving as "testimonial" in the form of student comments on my teaching evaluations.

Thoughts are rarely provoked by passive learning and memorization serves only to create limited and time-sensitive knowledge that is as quickly lost as it is gained. When I teach, I want my students to feel that what they gain is more than just "fun facts" about a different time and

place, but an expansion of how they see the world around them and a stronger confidence and ability to articulate themselves. I want my students to experience learning that gives them space to breathe, that recognizes and appreciates them in their individuality, and is as fun as a mandatory session on a Friday afternoon can be. To that end, I have achieved my goals, even if imperfectly, and that thrill and satisfaction drive me towards even more learning and training.

Teaching Statement

My experience as a first-generation college student and woman of color has directly informed my time in the university from my research interests to my teaching and community-building efforts. A desire to understand my experience of being mixed-race in Japan and the US led me towards topics such as race and gender and the histories of imperialism and colonialism that created and transformed them, but my divergence from the traditional university's singular model of what a student should be made it difficult. As a teacher, I espouse an ethic of flexibility that recognizes the structural inequalities, labor conditions, and educational disparities of my students and endeavors to create a space for students to learn without feeling like they need to leave a part of themselves at the door.

Creating an inclusive and accessible classroom requires open communication. In my classes, I circulate a "student info sheet," where students can let me know specifics that help them learn but also any potential barriers, whether that is a part-time job, a disability, or interpersonal problems that might affect their time or focus. With this information, I can incorporate more check-ins but also schedule one-on-one time to provide advice or to strategize how to ensure that the student does not fall behind. Although it is out of my control as teaching assistant, I have advocated for more flexibility in and refocusing of the requirements of courses, such as having softer deadlines, creating assessments that accommodate mistakes and absences, or improving the scaffolding of the course so that assignments are more likely to be accomplished by the final deadline. With open communication, students can feel secure that they will receive support and I can improve student learning experiences while planning to balance my workload accordingly.

The traditional model student is expected to have deference for hierarchy to "prove" their respect to the university/scholars, a quality that I lacked as a student and, which, as a teacher, I recognize as a potential barrier to improved learning. When the authority of the teacher looms over the classroom, students feel less inclined to voice their opinions out of fear of being wrong or of insulting the teacher's ego. I begin every quarter with a statement about my classroom ethos, emphasizing my belief that learning is not unidirectional (teacher to student), but multiple (student to teacher, student to student). I put this into practice by encouraging group activities and providing opportunities for students to give feedback on my teaching throughout the quarter. Beyond its immediate usefulness for me, soliciting feedback also encourages students to be more active in their learning. Nearly all my students pass my classes, but the impact of more inclusive learning is seeing how my students develop and become more active over the quarter, expressing themselves and asking challenging and thoughtful questions. Improvements between midterm and final exams/essays show not just their motivation but often their enthusiasm with some of my students' expressing interest in and taking more Japan-related courses.

Beyond creating structural flexibility and open communication, I foster intellectual curiosity in the coursework by highlighting its relevance to my students' everyday life particularly with respect to the history of concepts of race, gender, sexuality, (dis)ability and the way it directly shapes my students' experience in and outside of the university. I have given lectures about my research on mixed-race-ness at UCLA and abroad and discussed the personal experiences that led to my interest in this topic to motivate students to pursue their own research, leading to my writing letters of support for minority students pursuing studies in Asia. My dedication to improving the university's ability to support diverse scholars extends beyond the space of the classroom. During the George Floyd protests, I served in an online roundtable for

the Association of Asian Studies as well as a #BlackInTheIvory episode of the podcast *Japan on the Record* with other Black scholars to discuss barriers and provide suggestions to better support minority scholars. Through this, I was able to meet other minority scholars and form communities to discuss research and strategies for surviving academia. Public advocacy is crucial to build communities, but it also makes it explicit to your students that you practice what you preach, which is even more necessary in a moment where various groups are walking back their support of diversity.

I have been teaching in my department since 2018, and it has been a singularly transformative and satisfying experience. While I have listed both my teaching experience and pedagogical coursework, it does not include the workshops and discussions/exchanges with other teachers that have served as a valuable resource. Learning has always been its most impactful in my life when it shook the foundations of my knowledge and in so doing, sparked a thirst to learn more and it is this feeling that I try to make possible for my students, cultivating an inclusive classroom that recognizes and accommodates the diversity of my students needs so that they can focus and have space to expand their thinking.

Teaching Artifact #1 (Community of Care)

I make an active effort to express and provide care to my students. Below, I have included one example of a questionnaire (Student Information Sheet) that I use that gives my students the opportunity to consider their learning and advocate for themselves and for me to get information about who might need more attention early in the quarter. I ask my students to divulge a little bit about themselves, and, in exchange, my students can ask a little bit about me. This is just one way that I show my students that I "see" them. Other ways include memorizing my students' names, expressing my class ethos (learning as collaborative and fun), and regularly keeping track and reaching out to students when need be.

My students are typically very forthcoming and as a result, I can accommodate needs/desires even if informal and make note of and reach out to students one-on-one. For example, a student informed me that personal/familial issues were affecting his mental health and ability to do work. I scheduled regular meetings to encourage him to seek resources available at UCLA, but also to discuss strategies for being efficient with his time and effort and still pass the course. Not all students think of asking for help but since I keep track of each student, I can see when they are struggling. In this way, I found out, for example, a student who had difficulty listening/processing the lectures and reading because of his English language ability and a student who had broken her hand and had a hard time participating in an online learning environment. I worked with both students during office hours to go over content, provide study strategies, and help turn in assignments on time (serving as student's "hands" as she dictated).

While some students can be proactive about their learning and reach out to CAE, there are some students who might fall through the cracks, and this is what this information sheet and my active tracking are meant to catch. These are examples of students that needed more care, but my experience with them has taught and motivated me to think of ways to improve learning through accommodation not just in my sections but in the overall course, in discussion with my professors such as by providing more scaffolding or incorporating more flexibility.

Student Information Sheet

Name on class roster:

Preferred name (if different) and pronouns:

Is there anything I can do to make this class a better learning environment for you (large text on slides/handouts, alternatives to handwritten activities, etc.)?

Is there anything you'd like to let me know that might potentially impact your ability to participate in this class?

Anything else you'd like me to know about you?

Do you have any questions for me?

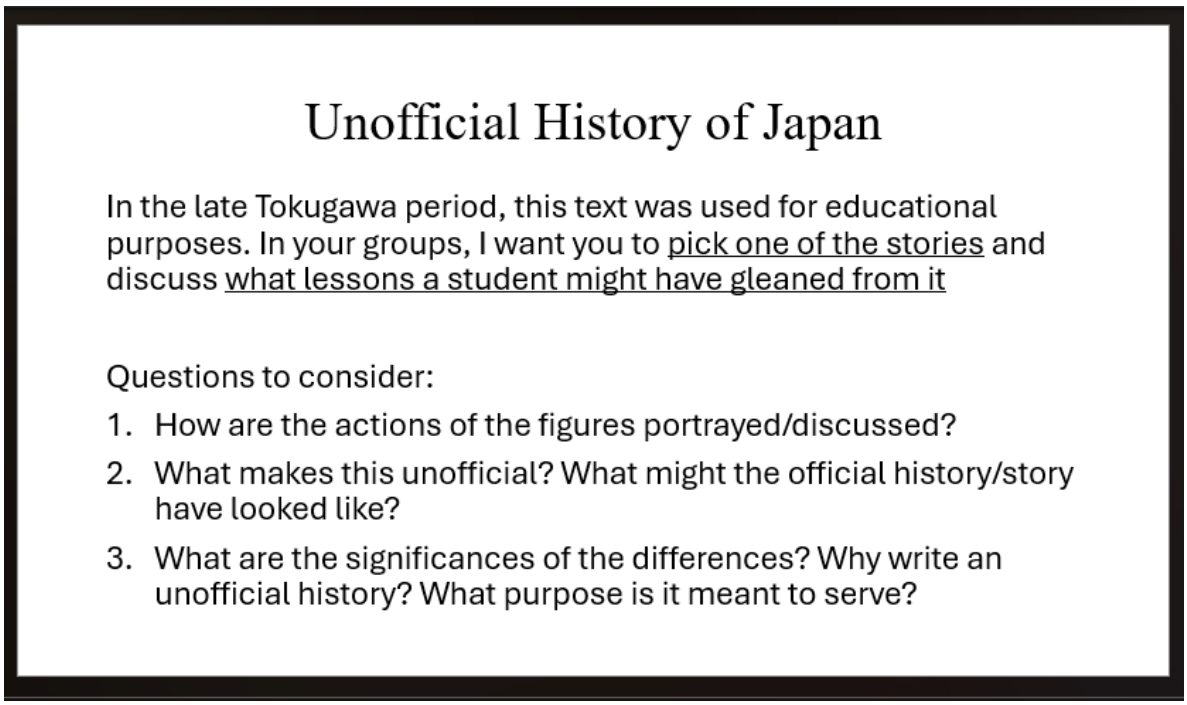
Teaching Artifact #2 (Approaching History)

Learning history can be a passive activity, so I have been creating activities geared towards critical thinking. These are two examples of exercise/activities I have used in the past year or designed with active student learning in mind.

Example #1:

This is an example exercise that was created to address feedback I have received from students and to encourage active student discussions. Students have noted that I often ask difficult questions or that I spend a lot of time talking. Part of this is that I use too "academic" of a language for students to understand and that I overexplain related context, but it is also from my desire to get through important points by the end of class and feeling that I cannot sacrifice too much time to prolonged silences. In addressing these points, simply having my discussion questions visible and allowing students time to think by incorporating 10-15 minutes of small group discussion before a general discussion has led to significant improvements in participation.

This is an example of a slide I used in Japanese Civilization about "The Unofficial History of Japan" by Rai San'yo.



Writing down my discussion questions helps me to phrase my questions as clearly as I can and students seem to prefer the visual rather than the verbal. This historical text was used for educational purposes and was part of an ideological movement that resulted in a significant transformation in Japan. Asking students to think of historical students and the impact that narratives about history can have in the transformation of day-to-day life is particularly

important because students often fail to understand why the study of history could matter for their lives.

Example #2

This is an activity for the beginning of Japanese history course that encourages students to think about how we know what we know for pre-writing civilizations. The activity includes a variety of images of historical artifacts for the period which have been removed for space. This was designed as part of a Writing Pedagogy course.

On Ancient Japan

Much of what we know about the ancient period, particularly before the prevalence of writing, is based on the work of archaeologists and anthropologists who piece together what life must have been like based on what remains from that time (material/objects). In this assignment, I want you to be the archaeologist.

Context: You are given special permission to enter one of the *kofun* tombs in an unnamed city in Kyushu. The tomb is the size of two soccer fields (roughly 200 meters), but the chamber itself is about the size of a standard American dorm room. Inside the burial chamber, you see:

Engraved stone coffin, murals, floor made of rocks, bronze swords and armor, rows of clay figures of animals/humans, intricate pots, large bronze mirrors one of which is engraved with ancient Chinese characters, *magatama* (curved stone beads), plates/bowls/goblets, metal jewelry (necklace/bangles/rings), bits of metal tools.

Task: Write a paragraph about what <u>you think life was like based off the objects listed in this tomb and make sure to explain your reasoning</u>. With a sense of what society/life might have been like, use this information <u>to explain the significance/purpose of one of the art objects</u> in the images at the end of the document.

If you are having a hard time here are some questions to consider:

What kind of person is buried here?

What might that say about societal structure?

Why might a person be buried with these items (what purpose did it serve/what might it say about beliefs regarding death)?

Was this society isolated?

Teaching Artifact #3 (Group Writing)

This is an example writing exercise created for J70 (Images of Japan) which has a writing assignment but does NOT teach writing to students. This is an example of how I adapted my section. I began by providing a brief overview of the concept of the "uncanny" and asking my students to apply the concept to a passage in *Ugetsu Monogatari*. The goal was to have groups of students write paragraphs on a shared google document and then as a class, we would go through the different examples and discuss what was effective and what might need improvement.

This ended up being a bit overambitious. Making it group work was supposed to make the writing process faster, but while some managed to finish quickly, others struggled to complete theirs by the end of class. While we were able to go over at least one example together as a class, I ended up having to provide feedback/comments/suggestions for the remaining unfinished paragraphs afterwards. Below, I have included the activity document that was shared with the class as well as an example paragraph written by students. Going forward, I would break this assignment into two sections/days. One to look at examples and discuss what makes an analytical paragraph "good;" then the other, students can try to create a paragraph together. My activity sheet requires editing but going forward, I would include definitions of the uncanny in the document itself and circulate it before section, so that students can think before coming to class.

Student Example #2

The uncanny is defined by unsettlingly familiar imagery, oftentimes of paranormal origin. In the *Reed-Choked House*, Katushiro returns home after seven years away in the capital and rather than being met with a familiar landscape he encounters a more barren land with fewer houses than before. Of the houses there, many he did not recognize. Katushiro is unable to even identify his own home as much of the land was overgrown with shrubbery, weeds, and vines. Coming back to a land that was once filled with many inhabitants and houses to now only be met with wildly grown farmland, broken down homes, and virtually no inhabitants brings about an unsettling feeling for Katushiro especially when his house seemingly remained intact. A place that once held memories and families being reduced to a wasteland, paired with his unchanged and seemingly unaffected house evokes a sense of anxiety from Katsushiro and readers alike. This feeling of uncanniness provides a stark realization to Katsushiro that his decisions and actions brought about dire outcomes. It would be fair to say that Katushiro viewing his house as intact and being able to see his wife is a display of his illusified world. This is a further extension of his selfish values and leaving home for his own greed to live in a world where everything is perfected for him, paying no mind to his actions. He views his house as intact and others around as riddled with shrubbery as his selfish desire led to this fantastical thought that nothing could harm him and that he could return back home with everything unchanged. Katsushiro wakes the next morning and is forced to face the reality that his wife is no longer alive and his house is no longer intact.

Ueda Akinari's *Ugetsu monogatari* (1776)

Task: Pick a passage from the selections below and write a paragraph arguing whether a passage/quote represents the "uncanny" and make this argument by providing a close reading of the text.

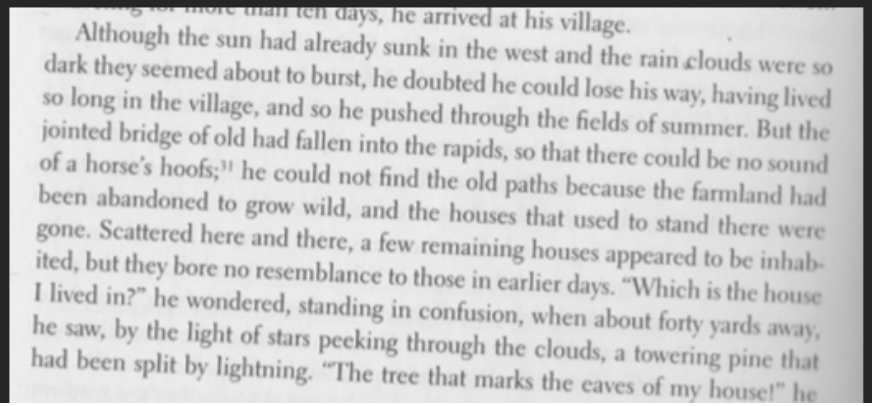
Important Components of Paragraph:

1. Defining what makes something "uncanny"
2. Brief description of the context of this selection
3. Show don't tell (Assume your reader has not read this story. Walk your reader through what is written, describe what effect this has, and explain your reasoning)
4. Connect this analysis back to your point about whether it is or is not uncanny
5. Consider how your analysis could change the interpretation of some aspect of the story, or what "purpose" you think the uncanny serves in the story or in a larger context, etc. (basically, why do you think this is important/interesting)

Link for Section 1E and Section 1F

Reed-Choked House

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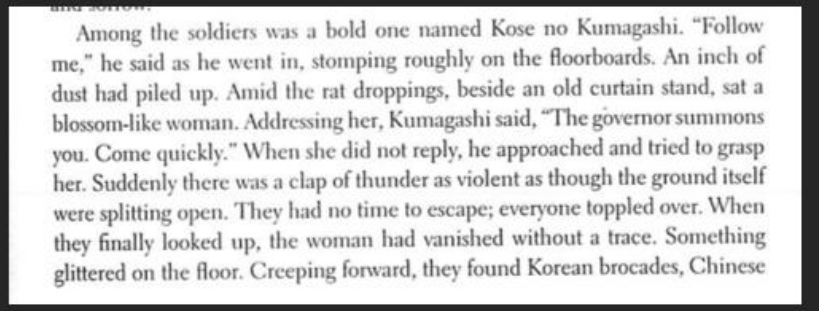


for more than ten days, he arrived at his village.

Although the sun had already sunk in the west and the rain clouds were so dark they seemed about to burst, he doubted he could lose his way, having lived so long in the village, and so he pushed through the fields of summer. But the jointed bridge of old had fallen into the rapids, so that there could be no sound of a horse's hoofs;[51] he could not find the old paths because the farmland had been abandoned to grow wild, and the houses that used to stand there were gone. Scattered here and there, a few remaining houses appeared to be inhabited, but they bore no resemblance to those in earlier days. "Which is the house I lived in?" he wondered, standing in confusion, when about forty yards away, he saw, by the light of stars peeking through the clouds, a towering pine that had been split by lightning. "The tree that marks the eaves of my house!" he

Serpent's Lust

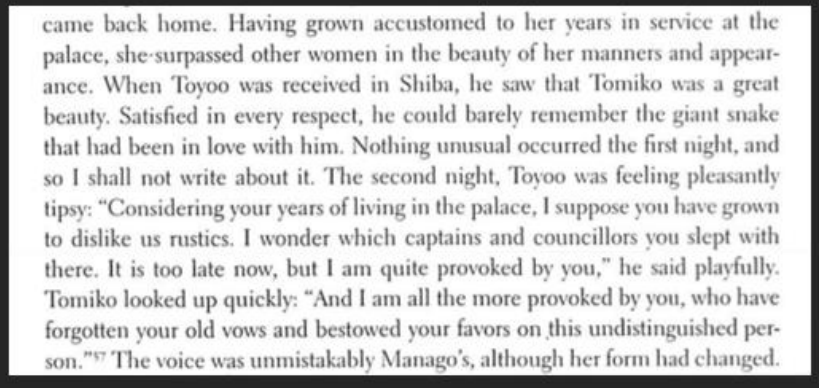
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and sorrow.

Among the soldiers was a bold one named Kose no Kumagashi. "Follow me," he said as he went in, stomping roughly on the floorboards. An inch of dust had piled up. Amid the rat droppings, beside an old curtain stand, sat a blossom-like woman. Addressing her, Kumagashi said, "The governor summons you. Come quickly." When she did not reply, he approached and tried to grasp her. Suddenly there was a clap of thunder as violent as though the ground itself were splitting open. They had no time to escape; everyone toppled over. When they finally looked up, the woman had vanished without a trace. Something glittered on the floor. Creeping forward, they found Korean brocades, Chinese

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came back home. Having grown accustomed to her years in service at the palace, she surpassed other women in the beauty of her manners and appearance. When Toyoo was received in Shiba, he saw that Tomiko was a great beauty. Satisfied in every respect, he could barely remember the giant snake that had been in love with him. Nothing unusual occurred the first night, and so I shall not write about it. The second night, Toyoo was feeling pleasantly tipsy: "Considering your years of living in the palace, I suppose you have grown to dislike us rustics. I wonder which captains and councillors you slept with there. It is too late now, but I am quite provoked by you," he said playfully. Tomiko looked up quickly: "And I am all the more provoked by you, who have forgotten your old vows and bestowed your favors on this undistinguished person."[57] The voice was unmistakably Manago's, although her form had changed.

Teaching Artifact #4 (Effective Feedback/Improved Assessment)

In my pedagogy seminars, I explored different grading rubrics and their pros and cons. A popular type of essay rubric breaks the essay down into many categories (ex. content, organization, voice, word choice, convention). For general education courses, this type felt unfair, because we would be assessing a student on something that might not have been taught to them and is certainly not taught in this class. For example, grammar/punctuation is a common category on such rubrics and while I agree with the need for essays to be readable and for students to properly edit, when this category is given equal weight to argumentation, it unfairly privileges native English writers and punishes English Second Language writers. In my Japan-related general education courses, I have advocated for assessments that are focused on what is taught in the course rather than a general assessment that assumes students come from the same education backgrounds. To that end, I have usually created and used a "holistic" rubric that is also easier for students to understand like the one below:

	A-Range	B-Range	C-range
Organization	Organized logically and coherently (easy to follow)	Mostly organized logically and coherently (the connection between some parts is hard to follow)	Somewhat organized logically and coherently (ok but mostly hard to follow)
Argumentation	The argument is clearly articulated and convincingly argued	Some minor problems with either the thesis statement or the argumentation	Minor problems with thesis AND argumentation or significant problems with the thesis OR argumentation
Analysis	Essay has original analysis and commentary of relevant textual examples	Essay engages with textual examples, but occasionally struggles to explain significance	No analysis, primarily plot summary

This is a very simple rubric but it makes providing feedback somewhat easier in that my comments and feedback will only be about these three categories. It is by no means perfect and while I have attended workshops (TLC) and courses on grading writing efficiently, none seem to really alleviate the heavy burden of providing thoughtful feedback for 50-60 students.

My essay feedback is always structured in two-parts: 1. In-essay comments on areas that need work 2. A summary of comments and advice. It is helpful for students to see exactly where

their paper needs work in-document, but providing a summary also allows space for encouragement and a “big picture” view.

These are examples of the summary feedback I gave students in the J70. They were required to write a 5-7 page argumentative paper on literature/film from the course that could be 1. related to big themes in course, 2. experimental reading, 3. comparison. In my evaluations, students mention how helpful my feedback was for improving their writing.

Example # 1

Hi Student A,

Your paper had some really compelling interpretations and analysis. In particular, I like your idea about how to understand the title. Throughout, you make a lot of good points, but some places need a little bit more explanation for how you are coming to that interpretation. Additionally, your paper could be more focused. There was a disjointedness because you are arguing that 1. Jihei is dead and 2. the kurokos (as representing society) control Jihei and, by extension, us. I see both points but I don't see why they are together. More could have been expanded in terms of the connection to these two. But, personally, I think simply having chosen one would really have allowed you more space to make a strong argument about for example, Jihei being dead. I think you show that he is associated with death or perhaps even damned/fated to die but is this necessarily the same as him being "dead all along.?" And if he is dead all along, how does this affect our understanding of the story?

Example #2

Hi Student B,

I liked your argument that certain environments in the film symbolically represented the two choices (desire vs. duty) and the "hardship" required to move from one to the other. But there were a couple of issues wrt to some of the logic of your argumentation. For example, you are often inconsistent in whether they have autonomy or do not. Additionally, I think more work needed to be done on the paragraph on open fields (is an outside space the same as an "in-between" space). Rather than these, I might have focused on the bridge because you could easily expand that first body paragraph to better connect liminality to autonomy/choice. They (and others) cross the bridge. They make their decision between the two and "transition" yet at the end, they are always found at the bridge (stuck in the in-between). I think this might have better supported idea of "inescapability." If we are bringing the director into it and relating it to some message about society/history, it kind of forces you to need to comment on why he choses this story for postwar (1960s) Japan. Yes, life might have been hard in Edo but why would he need to say this 300 years later?

Teaching Artifact #5 (Teaching Evaluations)

These are select comments received in my teaching evaluations that highlight different aspects of my pedagogical practice as described across my teaching statement, self-statement, and other teaching artifacts and across the three main courses I have taught.

J70 Teaching Evaluation Sample

Comments
I thought Yasmine was very transparent and real. She understands when students get caught up with other work, so she guides everybody through the reading material very thoroughly so that we're all on the same page before discussing as a class. She's always available to answer questions during section or through email, and her office hours are helpful. She's knowledgeable in the field and I recommend her for any future teaching endeavors!
Loved her. She's great at creating connections with the topics for discussing. She's very helpful and open with her students, and especially understanding when students have questions. Wish more TAs were like her.
Strengths: The ta seems to be passionate about what she is teaching to the class. She also addresses any of our questions very effectively. Weaknesses: I wish that for the discussions, there would be more small group discussions rather than the ta talking for majority of the time. I think that method is better for tracking participation.
probably my favorite TA I have had at UCLA. Yasmine was caring and really understood how to teach STUDENTS. I think she has a bright future ahead, if this wasn't a GE for me and it was my major, i would hope I'd get her as TA once again. Yasmine also answers emails super fast!
I believe the teaching assistant has a way in connecting with the student whether that is in class discussion or hosting office hours. She made herself available majority of the time which is something always nice to have or know that support is being offered. I would not say the TA had any form of weaknesses and did was she was assigned to really great! She helped serve as a main foundation such as guiding us or commenting on areas that would help.
The TA was very understanding and thorough with the discussion sections. She also seems to be very interested in the subject which made the class more Interesting.
My TA was amazing and helped me out greatly when I needed it.

Comments
Extremely accommodating and understanding of the students' situations, making sure that everyone had an opportunity to do the work they needed to and voicing our concerns to the professor when needed. Communicated well through discussion and emails, keeping us up to date about things the professor struggled to convey.
TA Yasmine was one of the best TA I had the opportunity to work with and learn Japanese literature from. The discussion section was always effective and efficient; I always left the section with more than just learning about the Japanese literature but also wide range of far and near historical contexts behind the literature and even relevant philosophical concepts that can be helpful in interpreting given text. Same was for her office hour, where TA Yasmine was very understanding, considerate, and efficient in explaining subjects with much more depth. Personally, there was no account of weakness of her teaching and her section. Through the class and TA's superb assistance, I was able to learn about Japanese texts, develop a strong conceptual understanding of them, and apply these insights in other classes.
Yasmine is very approachable and highly communicative. She always provides detailed summaries of what happens during a discussion that week and is very organized in her emails about course logistics. During office hours, Yasmine was very helpful in clarifying what she was expecting and what the course was expecting regarding postings or the midterm and final papers. She seemed genuinely invested in her work as a TA because she provided many feedback pointers on the midterm paper, which I had not had from a TA before. During discussions, she always offered her analysis of the films or texts we were analyzing that week. It was also helpful because it helped me understand other ways to evaluate scenes or quotes. I really do not have any weaknesses to say about Yasmine; she was a good TA.
The T.A was not particularly friendly but was definitely knowledgeable and passionate about the topics discussed in discussion sections.
she is amazing and very passionate and she understands us so she always tries to help us expand our knowledge on how to write good papers. i felt like i know how to write a paper better now after i went to office hours.

J80 Teaching Evaluation Sample

4. Comments:

4.1) Please identify what you perceive to be the real strengths and weaknesses of this teaching assistant and course.

- I don't have much to say regarding the discussion sections. I felt they were productive.
- I really appreciate how she's able to explain complicated course ideas/readings clearly because I wouldn't have been able to fully understand these ideas on my own. Also, I really appreciate how she encouraged verbal participation but also understood that not everyone is comfortable with sharing their ideas out loud and accepted written notes about the discussion as participation. She always encouraged people to come to her office hours for papers/extra help and was very clear that she wanted everyone to be successful in the course.
- I think Yasmine was knowledgeable about the course materials. I like the way in which discussions were carried out as it was much more open. Discussions flowed based on the input of our own opinions which was interesting.
- Really helpful TA. Met with her multiple times during her office hours and she helped me gather a lot of info on how to improve on my writings for the class.
- The strengths were knowledge and verbal skill the weakness was I didn't fully agree with grading.
- Was a very relatable person which allowed for a feeling that one could come if you needed the help. Was also understanding of students which allowed for better connection between students to TA.
- Yasmine was very helpful and she was very relatable/easy to talk to. For the most part, she was very effective in integrating the course with our readings and lecture. I think that the smaller setting is also very conducive to better discussions since it lets have more one-on-one discussions. Yasmine was also very helpful in unpacking the often times very wordy articles we had to read and made them more digestable for our writing assignments.

4. Comments:

4.1) Please identify what you perceive to be the real strengths and weaknesses of this teaching assistant and course.

- I feel like Yasmine remembers what it's like to be a student, she is realistic with her expectations of us and is good at discussing class topics in a self-aware way that we can relate to.
- One of my favorite TA's because of how knowledgeable and chill she is. Thanks for a great quarter!
- Yasmine made section very engaging and meaningful for her students. She aleays did her best to try to flesh out the deep, philosophical readings that were assigned so that students unaccustomed to these kinds of readings can still grasp the essence of the arguments. In addition, office hours were meaningful as Yasmine worked to help students with fleshing out their arguments for responses and papers. In addition, Yasmine is super chill and friendly, always down to help out her students or talk about her research. Overall, Yasmine made the course even more enjoyable and I look forward to taking more of her classes.
- Yasmine was definitely my favorite TA. She was my first TA my first quarter of my freshman year, and I was so excited to be in her discussion section again this quarter. She is extremely intelligent and knowledgable about all the topics discussed in class, and her office hours are extremely helpful as well. The first time I attended office hours, she explained to me what I could improve on in my weekly discussion posts and from that point on my scores drastically improved. Yasmine was so welcoming and helpful, and describes the information given in a way that's easy to understand in order to facilitate the process of relating those topics to the films/readings. I thoroughly enjoyed having her as my TA, and I am sad that I won't be in any of her future discussions. I hope her
- Yasmine's discussion sections were helpful, as they supplemented what we learned in lectures and clarified what I found confusing during the week. She also and allowed us to get extra help outside her normal office hours by arranging a meeting when it worked with our schedules.
- reviewed concepts and expanded upon ideas in lecture

J50 Teaching Evaluation Sample

4. Comments:

4.1) Please identify what you perceive to be the real strengths and weaknesses of this teaching assistant and course.

- I appreciated the recap aspect of discussions, I wish the class overall would have participated more, but that is just the nature of online learning. I felt that the discussions and the google doc recap added a lot to my understanding and full comprehension of the material and ability to answer the weekly prompt.
- I really liked how my teaching assistant tried to get everyone to participate and get to know one another. Every week she tried to put us into the same breakout rooms in Zoom so that we could hopefully familiarize ourselves with one another over the quarter. Although I can't say that I got to know too many of my classmates, I will say that my teaching assistant tried to create an environment in which anyone could share if they wished. I also thought that the grading was very fair. I liked the comments that she added as well, and found them very helpful if I wanted to do revisions. Overall, I really liked my teaching assistant and found this course very interesting and worthwhile.
- She was very caring and patient with everyone and very helpful during section. The discussion session was very organized and she conveyed ideas very clearly. She also was very helpful out of section as well.
- The TA was very detailed and helpful with the discussions.
- Their ability to build upon what the instructor covered throughout the week and condensing it into information that was relevant to the hw.
- Well organized, and always did a good job highlighting key course concepts

4. Comments:

4.1) Please identify what you perceive to be the real strengths and weaknesses of this teaching assistant and course.

- Much of where my discussion section with Yasmine fell short had to do with literally 4-6 students attending lectures by the second half of the quarter. Yasmine was a real MVP in carrying the discussion section. She didn't seem spiteful about people not attending optional discussion sections, and she even made an accommodating google doc for those who didn't attend. I did think it was helpful to attend the discussions to iron out any confusions, but she was really nice in making the document and sharing it with everyone else. Yasmine also sent out timely reminders each week about her consultation hours, and she put extra effort in trying to make each discussion section work. She tried many different ways across the quarter like reviewing the week's content by theme, by groups, by essay revisions, or by keywords and branching off there. I really appreciate how she changed that style depending on how many people attended/participated. Shows she cares... really good TA.
- Our TA is terrific!!
  She is so nice and patient.
- Very accommodating and gave constructive criticism on how to better write essays on particular Japanese historical topics.
- Yasmine is a really great TA and made sure the discussions were engaging. With the online learning environment, it makes it especially difficult for TA's to get the class to participate at times. I recommend, more so for the curriculum, that there could be participation extra credit or something to engage everybody into the conversation. Beyond that, Yasmine is very supportive and always willing to meet and answer any questions that students may have. I really enjoyed having us go through the week's assignment as a discussion because it made me feel assured that I was getting the right content in my assignments.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

For the final project, the professor had decided on a freeform option where we could pick one of three prompts to analyze any course media she'd covered. Yasmine encouraged our section to try the more open-ended prompt, which was a multimedia exploration of the material. I ended up submitting an analysis of the character design in Samurai Champloo, along with my drawings of how I would redesign them if the story were set in modern-day. I discussed my plan with Yasmine beforehand, and as we went over my ideas for the prompt, I only became more excited about completing the assignment. I hadn't had the chance to try something like this before, and I greatly enjoyed applying my interest (drawing) in an academic setting. It was genuinely the most fun I've ever had working on a school project, and I'm glad she inspired me to give my own take on it.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

During discussion, Yasmine would highlight certain film scenes/parts of the passages that were important to the purpose of the media or had a particular overarching symbolism, and ask us to share our interpretations of why it was impactful. Afterwards, she would discuss our responses and offer additional cultural background and/or her own analysis, allowing us to demonstrate our understanding and also learn more about why the creator of the media made certain choices in their writing/directing. After discussion, she would also send a comprehensive email containing her slides, additional important notes about the material she didn't have time to go over in detail, and helpful links (e.g. a film term glossary) that were all highly beneficial to our analysis of the week's media.

I often went to her office hours to ask for clarification on assignments; she was always very open to explaining her grading decisions, and what exactly she was looking for when reading my analyses. When discussing my outlines, she would ask my thought process instead of directly telling me whether it was "right" or "wrong", and I would gain a better understanding of how I wanted to present my ideas about the text/film.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

The way that Yasmine engaged with us during section facilitated a learning environment where everyone was very comfortable sharing their ideas about the material. When we were confused about what exactly our analyses should contain, she wrote up multiple examples and a detailed rubric to refer to. Her feedback on assignments was consistently detailed, timely, and constructive. Her grading was always fair, and if we struggled on a certain analysis, she'd spend extra time explaining how to improve for next week. Overall, I felt incredibly supported in my learning, and her role as my TA factored largely into that.

To whom it may concern,

Yasmine Krings, my TA for the course Jap 70, created a learning space focused on welcoming failure and learning from it. Unlike many courses I have taken at UCLA, Yasmine's classroom has been the most welcoming, helpful, and most important creative.

I will attend her office hours almost every week during the winter quarter in 2025. While I came in confused from lecture material or readings, Yasmine helped me through it all. What really challenged me was that she didn't give me the answers, instead she asked me questions about what I was confused about, which helped me much more than just getting answers. I was able to truly understand the materials.

I found myself excelling as time went on, thanks to her discussion sections and office hours. I also found it to be beneficial that my organizational skills for papers were significantly improved from all the help and tips Yasmine gave me. For example, during the last office hours of hers I attended during finals week, I came in with what I think was some of my best work. It wasn't basic, it was a demonstration of my understanding of how to interpret images from these movies, all because Yasmine taught me how to understand the concepts and organize my thoughts. I could tell after showing it to Yasmine that she was impressed with what I have learned from her about creating organized outlines. Thanks to Yasmie, I received an A in the class, making me feel as though I actually learned something from a general education class.

She told me about her story and how she wants to be a professor teaching students about literature and film. It was clear that her passion for this curriculum is strong, and it would be a shame for her not to be recognized for the help she has given to all her students. I would recommend Yasime to those who need help with their writing skills because Yasmine is a patient teacher getting one to the level they need to be at.

From,

Reese Niemela

Political Science Student 2027

Victoria Davis, Japan

UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES **UCLA**

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January 25, 2026

I am writing to nominate Yasmine Krings for the Distinguished TA Award. In the winter 2025 quarter, Yasmine served as a TA for Japan 70 "Japanese Literature and Film," a large general education course I taught in which more than two-hundred students enrolled. Yasmine led two weekly discussion sections, for each of which she graded weekly postings and both midterm and final papers. At the same time, without my ever asking her to do so, she naturally and very effectively assumed the role of head TA among the five Ph.D. students. Her performance was exemplary in all ways, but I would particularly like to highlight her success in engaging students from diverse backgrounds and helping them make strides.

I was impressed with Yasmine's inclusive and flexible pedagogy, which made students feel comfortable in the classroom and invited them to participate actively in conversations. As a first-generation college graduate and one of a very small number of mixed-race Black scholars in the field of Japanese studies—a field populated mostly by white and Asian scholars—Yasmine has drawn on her own experiences to develop effective pedagogical approaches that engage and inspire students from a wide range of backgrounds in the pursuit of the humanities. She emphasizes multidirectional conversations in small-group settings, while also thoughtfully interjecting during full-class discussions to encourage students to unpack important ideas that might otherwise be glossed over, and to think more deeply as a group. She strove to meet students where they were—validating their perspectives while still pushing them to think more critically. Yasmine is truly an exceptional teacher.

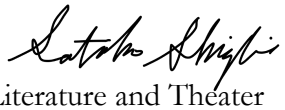
Needless to say, exceptional teaching matters because it enables exceptional learning. When I taught Japan 70, I could see very clearly how much progress Yasmine's students made over the course of the quarter, especially from the midterm to the final paper. Conversations with several of Yasmine's students gave me a sense of how much time Yasmine spent holding individual meetings with students to brainstorm ideas for papers; then providing detailed, concise comments on their writing to help them identify areas for improvement; and, often, meeting again to talk with them about their finished papers and the comments she had provided on them.

I would like to add, as a sidenote, that Yasmine is a dynamic and socially engaged scholar who, even as a Ph.D. student, has been invited to participate with senior Black scholars in Asian studies in roundtables at major conferences, and in at least one podcast, to discuss barriers in academia and the ways in which scholars in our field might better support and inspire students from underrepresented backgrounds. Yasmine's dedication to inclusivity and engagement with social issues touches students,

making them intellectually more curious, helping them to connect what they learn in class to the larger world outside.

Yasmine has been a genuinely inspiring teacher for undergraduate students who have taken classes in the department of Asian Languages and Cultures. I am thrilled and honored to nominate her for the teaching award.

Satoko Shimazaki



Associate Professor of Japanese Literature and Theater
Director of Graduate Studies
Asian Languages and Cultures
University of California, Los Angeles